



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of St. Mary's
School Website: <https://www.chestertonstmarys.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of St. Mary's (Maryland) presents a robust, nearly fully aligned Classical Catholic curriculum and pedagogy. Public materials portray a mission centered on forming virtuous, thoughtful young people through a classical liberal arts framework, explicit Catholic theology, the Socratic method, and a culture of life. The school emphasizes a three-pillar model (Intellect, Character, Spirituality), integrates liturgical life (daily Mass, retreats) with rigorous study across literature, philosophy, history, theology, languages, and the arts, and foregrounds parental involvement and a house-system culture. Taken together, these elements indicate a CLASSICAL orientation across all evaluated categories, with strong evidence of formation, Great-Books-adjacent study, Socratic pedagogy, and intentional community practices.

Key public signals include: a mission to form joyful leaders and saints within a Catholic, classical framework; daily Mass and retreats; integration of Catholic theology across disciplines; a three-pillar approach to formation; a Socratic, integrated humanities curriculum; a robust Fine Arts program including choral singing, speeches, and debate; and active family/parent engagement through open houses and events. These indicators line up with classical-education lexicon such as the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty; formation over information; Great Books/Great Conversation notions; and the governance of a living curriculum through dedicated faculty and community practices. All six categories thus trend toward CLASSICAL. See category-by-category details below for the explicit keyword signals, supporting quotes, and the analytic rationale.

Citations illustrating core publicly stated elements include: the mission and Catholic identity (turn0file0; turn0file2); the three-pillar model (turn0file3); the Socratic method and classical curriculum (turn0file0; turn0file4); a structured humanities curriculum with grade-by-grade literature/history focus (turn0file4); the Fine Arts emphasis and liturgical aspects (turn0file7); and explicit faculty/house-system and daily Mass/liturgical life in personnel-related notes (turn0file10). Additional corroboration on Catholic formation, liturgy, and formation-oriented language appears across related Chesterton site materials (turn0file1; turn0file3; turn0file8). For the classical-education rubric and keyword mapping, see the Six Essential Elements document (Positive/Negative keyword indicators) (turn0file12) and the associated lexicon (turn0file5).

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials frame education as grounded in Catholic theology and metaphysical aims: "educated in the Classical tradition and the truths of the Catholic faith," with emphasis on sanctity and leadership in service of God (turn0file2; turn0file0). - The mission emphasizes daily Mass, retreats, and Catholic teaching integrated across disciplines, indicating liturgical and communal life as integral to formation (turn0file0; turn0file3). - The explicit reference to "theology integrated into each subject," and the overall Catholic, sacramental framing ("Christ our Lord," Magisterium fidelity) appear throughout materials (turn0file1; turn0file3).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Catholic theology, Mass, liturgy, sacred tradition, truth, beauty, virtue, wonder, Logos, prudence, justice, mercy; daily Mass; theology across disci-

plines; sacred time (Mass/retreats). - Negative keywords present: none observed in public materials (no explicit secular-relativism or values-clarification signals).

Calculation note: Positive signals (e.g., Catholic faith; theology; liturgy; virtue; wonder; sacredness) clearly outweigh any non-classical signals; no negative indicators detected in the public materials.

Why this rating - The materials consistently position the school as grounded in a transcendent, Catholic metaphysical framework with liturgical practice and communal worship as foundational. The explicit integration of theology across subjects, worship life, and a “culture of life” orientation aligns strongly with the Classical School’s Religious and Metaphysical Foundations criteria. The presence of the threefold framing (truth, goodness, beauty) and liturgical life supports a CLASSICAL assessment here (see references above).

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission centers on formation of virtue and human excellence through a classical education rooted in Catholic tradition (turn0file0; turn0file2). - The school articulates a telos oriented toward wisdom and virtue, not merely job-readiness, along with a focus on forming leaders and saints for lifelong service (turn0file0; turn0file3). - The Three Pillars model (Intellect, Character, Spirituality) explicitly frames education as formation, not mere information (turn0file3).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, wisdom, telos, great conversation, classical tradition, sacred/eternal truths, contemplation. - Negative keywords present: none detected (no explicit emphasis on workforce-centric or purely job-oriented language in the public materials).

Calculation note: Strong positive keyword presence with no explicit negative signals.

Why this rating - The materials repeatedly emphasize formation of virtue and wisdom as the goal of education, a classical telos, and a commitment to a liberal-arts formation that aligns with the “formation, not information” criterion. The explicit Three Pillars and culture-of-life framing further reinforce CLASSICAL status in Element 2.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials describe a classical curriculum core: focus on classical literature, philosophy, science, mathematics, history, and Latin (turn0file0). - The humanities program is threaded through a braided study of history, literature, philosophy, theology, and languages with a Socratic method (turn0file4). - Grade-level humanities sequencing emphasizes a coherent historical arc (Ancient World, Early Medieval, High Middle Ages to Renaissance, Modern World) and integrated study of literature with history (turn0file4). - The Fine Arts program includes music, art, drama, and rhetoric as essential components of education (turn0file7).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; quadrivium components like arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy), Great Books/Great Conversation notions (classical canon, primary sources) though explicit phrase usage varies; Latin; history integrated with other disciplines; wonder/formation emphasis; interdisciplinarity. - Negative keywords present: none detected in public materials; there is no explicit “social studies-only” or STEM-first framing in place of history or Great Books.

Calculation note: The school’s curriculum content strongly aligns with classical markers; positive keyword hits substantially outnumber any potential negative signals.

Why this rating - Curriculum materials clearly reflect the core classical elements: liberal arts emphasis, integration of Great Books- or Great-Conversation-leaning study through literature/history/philosophy/theology/Latin, and an explicit emphasis on wonder and depth across grades. The Fine Arts and music/drama components reinforce the broad liberal-arts approach. These indicators justify CLASSICAL for Element 3.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly follows the Socratic method of teaching (turn0file0). - The Humanities Program notes use of integrated curricula with a raised focus on the Socratic Method (turn0file4). - Lower- and upper-school pedagogy references appear: lower-school activities (singing, memory work, chanting) and upper-school Socratic discussions; opportunities for rhetoric development and public speaking (turn0file7, turn0file4). - A Restful-Scholé dimension is present in classical pedagogy discussions in the knowledge base lexicon; the Chesterton materials show a combination of contemplative/sequence-based pedagogy (memory work, recitation, chant) and Socratic seminars, debates, or rhetoric training (turn0file5; turn0file18).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue/seminar, dialectic, questioning, memorization/recitation/chanting, Scholé (restful learning), formation through imitation and practice, rhetoric, debate, civil discourse, guided discussion. - Negative keywords present: absence of negative signals such as exclusive reliance on experiential/project-based learning as the sole method; no explicit “constructivist-only” or non-traditional pedagogy signals in public materials.

Calculation note: The public materials demonstrate a predominant classical pedagogy signature, with strong signals for Socratic inquiry and memory-based learning, plus contemplative/restful elements.

Why this rating - Pedagogical methods are clearly aligned with classical standards: Socratic pedagogy in upper grades, memorization/chanting in lower grades, and a rhetoric/eloquence emphasis in upper grades; contemplative/restful learning (Scholé) is also indicated. Taken together, these signals support CLASSICAL for Element 4.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The materials identify a headmaster with a defined faculty, noting the size (e.g., “Headmaster and 11 faculty” in published materials) and the presence of a house system, daily Mass, and spiritual formation activities that faculty support (turn0file1; turn0file9). - Faculty involvement in spiritual life (daily Mass, spiritual retreats) and in forming character is highlighted, suggesting a living-curriculum model in which faculty are exemplars and mentors (turn0file9). - The public materials describe faculty as part of a “Three Pillars” formation and the school’s culture of virtue; there are references to a portrait or living-model curriculum for teachers and students (turn0file3; turn0file9).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum, faculty as mentors, portrait of a teacher, collegial culture, master-teacher model, character formation, spiritual leadership, daily Mass with student body. - Negative keywords present: none observed in public materials.

Calculation note: Positive keyword hits dominate; no explicit negative signals about faculty in the materials.

Why this rating - The school’s public materials frame faculty as critical, virtuous models who embody and deliver the classical curriculum—a hallmark of classical education cultures. The references to the house system, daily Mass, and faculty involvement in spiritual life further support CLASSICAL in Element 5.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Chesterton site presents extensive parent-facing events and opportunities (open houses, admissions events, “Discover Chesterton” opportunities) and emphasizes partnerships with families and co-teaching roles; materials indicate families are deeply engaged with the school’s mission and activities (turn0file10; turn0file8; turn0file4). - The mission and program emphasize “partnership with families,” parent formation (book studies, gatherings), and a welcoming environment where parents are invited to visit the school (turn0file12; turn0file4; turn0file8). - Community activities such as galas and open houses are highlighted as part of school life, signaling active parent involvement and community integration (turn0file4; turn0file8).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families/co-teachers, parent formation, classical community culture, open campus/visits, family participation, parental engagement.

- Negative keywords present: none observed in public materials (no consumer-oriented or minimal-parent involvement signals).

Calculation note: Maternal signals (parental partnership, home-school synergy, and community events) strongly indicate CLASSICAL in Element 6.

Why this rating - The materials reflect a deliberate, ongoing partnership with parents and a community oriented toward classical formation, including family formation and accessible school visits. This aligns with the Parents & Community criteria for CLASSICAL.

Aggregate Assessment - All six categories are CLASSICAL based on the public material evidence and keyword analyses above. The Chesterton Academy of St. Mary's demonstrates a cohesive classical-Catholic approach characterized by formation, a liberal-arts curriculum, Socratic pedagogy, a living faculty, and an engaged, formation-focused parent/community culture.

What Would Move the Needle - No major needle-moving changes appear necessary given the CLASSICAL results across all six categories. If desired, minor enhancements could include explicit, public articulation of "Great Books/Great Conversation" language in site copy to further align with canonical classical lexicon, and additional explicit language about "Scholé" and "memory work" in the public-facing curriculum overview to strengthen the Pedagogy signal for future audiences.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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